Maharashtra: Economic Powerhouse

It is the financial capital of the country, but in recent times, some technological innovations have been happening.

Registration of New Vehicles, Issue of Licenses, Tax Collections and Defaulter Prosecutions: Developed for the Motor Vehicle Department of Maharashtra.

Stamps and Registration Project: Clearing backlogs. Department staff trained for software. Plans to integrate all 300 offices in a phased manner.

Department of Irrigation: A comprehensive MIS for the Department of Irrigation, Government of Maharashtra.

Integrated Information System for the Sales Tax Department: The system is designed to facilitate electronic business such as electronic filing of returns and payment of taxes. Most application forms will be available on the Web, which can be downloaded and used.

These projects are just some of the initiatives taken by the government, and the administration has met with success in its ventures.

The state has given IT top priority and that is evident in the International Infotech Park set up at Vashi, Navi Mumbai. Besides this, the government is also keen on setting up a Millennium business park.

Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) has helped to lay telecom ducts with fibre optic capacity for various prospective users.

information kiosks, called soochnalayas, catering to the everyday needs of the people, whether they are related to commerce, education or health.

According to Rajesh Rajora, Collector, Dhar District, "We started off with e-governance services in the quest to bridge the digital divide. The network has shown outstanding results, with more than 55,000 users in the last 18 months. One out of two users belong to the Below Poverty Line families, one out of three users belong to the SC and ST category and one of seven users are illiterate! The network has empowered the disempowered."

Its innovative use of the administrative system and functioning has won Gyandoot the Stockholm Challenge IT Award 2000 in June last year. Gyandoot was declared winner in the 'Public Service and Democracy' category out of 109 IT projects from all over the world. It was also awarded the CSI-TCS National IT Award for best IT usage, instituted by the Computer Society of India, for the year 2000.

Behind the scenes

The entire expenditure for the Gyandoot network has been borne by the village panchayats and private entrepreneurs. The total initial cost was Rs 25 lakh, with additional investment from private parties for expansion of the project. The average cost incurred in establishing a single kiosk was Rs 75,000.

The kiosks have dial-up connectivity through local exchanges on optical fibre or UHF links. As of now, the system is hosted on a Pentium III Remote Access Server (RAS) located in a computer room of the zilla panchayat and connected to all the soochnalayas. Keeping in view the widespread power cuts in rural areas, the soochanalayas have been equipped with UPS systems that can run the computer and printer for four hours at a stretch without power.

Out of 34 soochanalayas, 25 already have optical fibre connectivity. And by the end of June 2001, the remaining would also be connected through optical fibre lines. "We have gone into Wireless in Local Loop technology developed by corDECT/TeNet in IIT Chennai," says Rajora. "This state-of-the-art technology provides 70 Kbps bandwidth along with wireless telephony. Phase I of the technology has already been introduced," he adds.

A simple menu-driven Hindi software is used in the machines, which requires minimum data entry at the client end. Gyandoot Samiti, a registered society, supports the project to run the intranet and various services. Local people manage the soochnalayas, so this not only generates employment, but they are also able to handle and resolve queries faster, through their understanding of the local processes.

Case II: Land in my hand

Just about a year ago, Karnataka's farmers faced the delay-n-corruption drill if they wanted to procure the record of rights and tenancy and cultivation certificate (RTC). Now, the state government's initiative to computerise land records under the Bhoomi scheme and issue printed RTCs has come like a boon for them.

The details of all land records can be obtained from one of the 40 touch-screen kiosks installed at the various taluka offices in Karnataka, at the cost of a mere Rs 15. The state has some 6.7 million farmers and 17 million land records spread over 30,000 villages, and is spending a hefty amount to digitise all the documents.

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> **Rajeev Chawla**
> Additional Secretary (Revenue), Govt. of Karnataka

Rajeev Chawla, the additional secretary (Revenue) of the Government of Karnataka vouches for the success of this scheme. "The success rate of the e-governance implementation is such that the Government of India has requested the entire team behind the e-governance initiative to visit other states and try helping them replicate this model so that the concept of e-governance catches up in as many states as possible," he says.

Trading the old for the new

The land record computerisation software, called Bhoomi, has been designed by NIC, Bangalore. The initial data entry is done at the taluka level through private data entry agencies. After that, printouts are taken, which are validated by comparing them to the original land records books. After this correction, the data is ported onto Bhoomi.

This software incorporates online updating